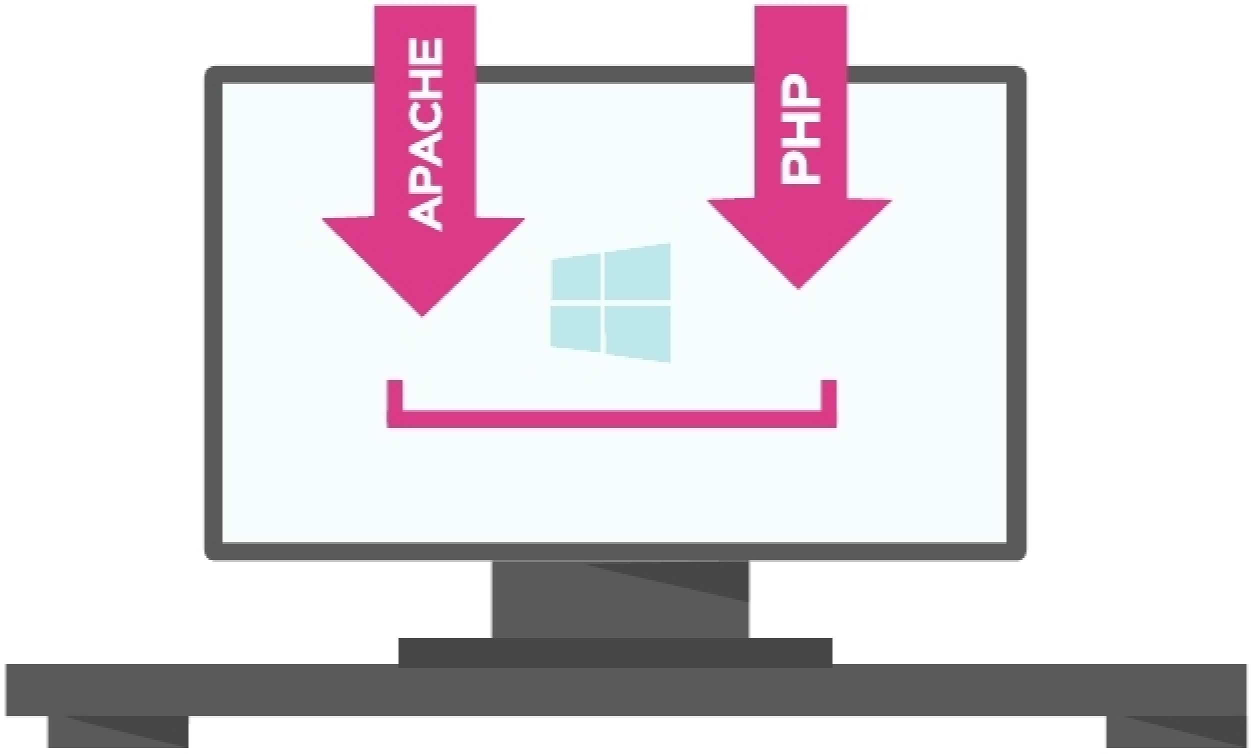

Setting Up Apache and PHP in a Windows Development Environment

Web servers are generally dominated by GNU/Linux based software, whereas Windows has the lion's share of desktop PCs. Web development tools are generally more focused on the Linux environment, but Windows developers can take advantage of the Windows variants to develop applications on their OS, and later deploy these on an appropriate server.

The LAMP stack is a well known setup that powers a big portion of the Internet. LAMP stands for Linux, Apache, MySQL and PHP. A similar Windows variant is called WAMP, where W stands for Windows. WAMP can be used to develop dynamic websites quickly and take advantage of the battle-tested tooling that comes with it.

Let's set up Apache and PHP in a Windows development environment.

Note: This tutorial assumes this is being done in a development and not a production server. For production, it is generally recommended that a GNU/Linux based OS is used.

Apache

The Apache HTTP server is free and open source Web server software and is ranked the second most popular after Nginx. Apache is the application the outside world contacts to access the Web pages, which in turn use one of its modules to generate content based on the requests.

Apache is extensible and can be extended by using Apache Modules for additional features.

PHP

PHP: Hypertext Preprocessor is a programming language designed for Web development. It enables users to create dynamic Web pages that can interact with a database, handle state and make changes at the server level. PHP code is run through the PHP interpreter, which is called by Apache upon a request. It then prepares a response for the request and sends it back to Apache for the user.

PHP is primarily a dynamically typed language, which also supports optional type declarations on function parameters and returns values enforced at runtime. PHP code can be mixed with HTML code to generate output, although it goes against the best practices.

There are packages like WAMP Server and XAMPP that pack all the necessary applications including Apache and PHP together in a